6.3 The Release Calendar That Dominates Quarters

Elite private strategy - not for redistribution

WAR-ROOM NOTES - 6.3 The Release Calendar That Dominates Quarters

CAPACITY PLANNING, NOT CREATIVITY (THE OPERATOR'S FRAME)

The dominant constraint on radio success is armed campaigns, not musical output. Each armed campaign requires roughly 40 hours of machine time: targeting (6h), weapons (8h), load (4h), sends (3h), follow-up (5h), proof farms (10h), audit (4h). At three releases a year, that's ~120 hours - sustainable. At six releases, the per-release hours collapse below the armed threshold, and each release underperforms its own potential. The calendar's "three a year" is a math decision, not an artistic taste decision.

THE W-8 GATE (THE MOST VIOLATED CHECKPOINT)

The single most common calendar failure: at W-8, the artist "doesn't have time" for the full arm - so the campaign fires half-loaded and underperforms by 50%. W-8 is the load-sequence gate: if less than 15 of 20 stations are at 7/7 gates, the operation's date slips - not the release date, the campaign date. Skip W-8 once and the whole year becomes a fire drill. Never skip it.

THE QUARTERLY OFFSET (SEASONAL RADIO BEHAVIOR)

Radio's attention is cyclical: January (post-holiday open), February (spring adds), April (spring campaign), June (summer), September (fall push), October-December (ratings season - cold for unknowns). Operators slot releases into the open windows (Jan/Feb, Apr/May, Sep/Oct) and use the closed windows (Nov/Dec) for proof-building and the annual audit. Releasing into a closed window isn't brave; it's a donation.

THE CALENDAR AS THE ASCENSION ARTIFACT

A completed 12-month calendar with 3 armed campaigns, 30+ adds, and a revenue ledger isn't just a personal tool - it's the ascension evidence (Module 6.4): the exact artifact that tells a manager, label, or campaign service "this artist runs a professional operation." The unarmed artist gets a mentor. The calendar-running artist gets an investment. Build the artifact.